

## **Three Keys to Success: Apprenticeship Development for Rural Youth with Disabilities**

*Insights from the Rural Youth Apprenticeship Development Project's Advisory Council*



The Rural Youth Apprenticeship Development (RYAD) project promotes the development and advancement of vocational rehabilitation programs for youth with disabilities (aged 16–24 years) in rural communities. The RYAD Project's Advisory Council members gathered to discuss family engagement, financial literacy, mentorship, and the interplay of these topics in the context of apprenticeships. Participants included disability researchers, apprenticeship program administrators and evaluators, and representatives of the Department of Labor. This brief captures the discussion, considerations, and ideas generated in this meeting to illustrate how to develop successful rural youth apprenticeship programs that promote family engagement, educate about financial literacy, and provide mentorship.

### **FAMILY ENGAGEMENT**

Family engagement refers to collaborative partnerships and relationship-building between agencies and families of transitioning youth. Ideally, family engagement is a strengths-based process with shared responsibility between individuals and agencies that promotes positive outcomes for youth while addressing family concerns and goals.

The importance of quality family engagement in apprenticeship programs cannot be overstated. Youth seeking apprenticeships are transitioning between worlds. They need support from family members accompanying them through their life changes. To accomplish this, participating youth and their families must understand the implications of transitioning from benefits to employment and how to set themselves up for success. Family members must understand, and perhaps be coached on, how to support and encourage their youth throughout this potentially stressful and unsettling process.

## Maintaining Community Culture

Family engagement is instrumental in maintaining an awareness of family and community hierarchy and priorities when planning for an apprenticeship. In American Indian communities and others with defined traditions, this also includes cultural hierarchies and practices. Families can help ensure that youth entering apprenticeship programs secure opportunities that allow them to maintain their cultural traditions and identities while they transition. For example, does the youth belong to a matriarchal or patriarchal culture? Which elder needs to be present for different activities? What are the family expectations of the youth? What are the expectations of the youth's family members? Are there local examples of successful transitions that can help guide them through the process?



## Communicating and Understanding Expectations

Family engagement is driven by the need for families to understand the expectations of an apprenticeship program. What do different apprenticeship programs expect from youth and their families? What support will the youth need? How will employment needs fit into the family schedule? Will the youth need a mentor or additional family members to reach their goals?

Using clear language to explain the program, benefits, expectations, and responsibilities is vital. Youth and families need explanations so they can understand and stay on the same page. School counselors can be a resource in determining an appropriate messenger for reaching and communicating with families and community members. Programs can offer workshops to educate families on apprenticeships, discuss benefits and accommodations, share success stories, and invite mentors and apprenticeship employers to speak. Ongoing family engagement helps maintain a communication channel and facilitates a smooth, sustainable transition from benefits to employment.

## FINANCIAL LITERACY

Financial literacy refers to a person's understanding of how to handle money effectively. This includes the knowledge and ability to earn, budget, save, and protect their money. Financial literacy allows people to make informed decisions about money.

Youth exploring apprenticeship and their families will likely need financial literacy training to succeed. They will need to understand the financial implications and expectations of apprenticeships. Youth may need related technical instruction (RTI), which often has associated tuition costs. Financial aid or employer-funded opportunities may be available to pay for any required training. Youth and families should discuss resources and avenues for support services that can provide initial direction and help throughout the process.





## Planning for Success

In families that include people with disabilities, it is common for Social Security benefits (Supplemental Security Income and Social Security Disability Insurance) to be a core family support. As a result, the transition from benefits to employment can affect the entire family dynamic. Supporting both youth and their families in understanding the financial implications of apprenticeship, including the potential for earnings, is instrumental. Apprenticeship programs should address a family's fears and apprehensions, providing information, support, and benefits planning at the outset of the process. This support may include counseling on ABL (Achieving a Better Life Experience) accounts, identifying resources for financial aid and tuition costs, employer and agency-funded opportunities, and avenues for available support services.

The goal of an apprenticeship is to incorporate the ideas of independent living to support financial independence for transitioning youth. To accomplish this, youth and their families must understand the numbers, such as the return on investment (ROI) of apprenticeship programs and the amount of work and time they can anticipate. Defined goals and a shared understanding of anticipated financial changes help establish reasonable expectations and effectively prepare participants and their families for transition to apprenticeship programs.

## MENTORSHIP

Mentorship means guidance from another individual to support the professional growth of a transitioning youth. Mentorship is a relationship based on trust. A trusted mentor advises youth on navigating a major life change based on the goals of the youth and their families.

Youth transitioning from benefits to employment can learn a lot from having a mentor with experience in transition, apprenticeship, or the specific industry or trade; however, even suitable mentors may need training on how to be a mentor. Youth and their families should have questions to help select an appropriate mentor who meets their cultural needs and can help them reach their employment goals. This will help make an informed choice and identify any additional training, resources, and supports needed to provide high-quality mentorship. Mentors should bring excitement and “a new line of hope” that includes family involvement and a shared understanding of the impact of mentorship or pre-apprenticeship. This is critical for reaching rural youth, especially on reservations.



## Who Should be a Mentor?

Suitable apprenticeship mentors must be vetted, undergo a background check, and possess appropriate background knowledge. They need to have experience with or an understanding of disability to plan appropriately and prevent disability stereotypes from serving as a barrier to the mentor/mentee relationship. Youth may want to explore self-employment, a common career track for people with disabilities. These youth would likely need a mentor with experience and understanding that includes both disability and self-employment, who could help them navigate starting their own business.

Mentors also need to understand the distinctions between pre-apprenticeship and registered apprenticeship programs (RAP). The program design and expectations are distinct, and RAP has more specific guidelines than exploring a job through a pre-apprenticeship. While RAP is a structured program with proven effectiveness in gaining credentials in a specific occupation, pre-apprenticeship is a valuable avenue for preparing youth for their career trajectory.

## Pre-Apprenticeship Mentors

Pre-apprenticeship mentors help facilitate decision-making by providing guidance, education, and experience. Particularly when transitioning from benefits to employment, the perspective gained through these activities is instrumental in setting participating youth on a successful track. Pre-apprenticeship mentorship may include identifying career pathways and potential employers. Specific benefits of pre-apprenticeship include:



- » Hands-on opportunities to explore industries and specific occupations to gauge personal interest and mutual fit for the youth and employer. Youth can explore the factors that define apprenticeships, from automotive work and skilled trades to traditional crafts such as pottery and weaving.
  - [Work Hands](#) is an app that shares information between mentors, teachers, and students to keep everyone on the same page.
- » Opportunities to explore shared experience with different agencies. Lived experience with disability and connections to resources can improve pre-apprenticeship outcomes and relationships. Centers for Independent Living can take a role by emphasizing disability pride and how to live and engage in the community.
- » Education and understanding of disability for mentors, sponsors, and employers. Are stereotypes or stigma unintentionally incorporated in the mentorship or apprenticeship? What needs to occur to overcome such barriers in the relationship?
- » The opportunity to take a “grow your own” approach to mentorship rooted in shared experiences, local and cultural values, and geographic identity.
- » The ability to factor the school year and summer activities into planning. How are local youth spending their summers, and are youth activities available to maintain momentum and excitement? There is potential for partnerships with Boys & Girls Clubs, tribal community colleges, immersion schools for language and tradition, and other youth-centered organizations.
- » The opportunity for youth to develop reliability and responsibility, and to become eager, self-directed learners that employers are looking for. The Department of Labor provides guidance to all parties on how to create a high-quality pre-apprenticeship program. This guidance complements local collaboration and efforts to maintain identity and values.

## CONCLUSION

High-quality youth apprenticeships are multifaceted and require a high level of collaboration and coordination. Family engagement, financial literacy, and mentorship are interwoven throughout the process of developing apprenticeships and will look different in various situations. It is vital that agencies, transitioning youth, and their families work together to understand the goals and expectations for each apprenticeship and each apprentice. This shared understanding helps ensure that each person knows their role and their collective purpose. By taking an intentional approach centered on communication and consideration of all individuals, apprenticeship programs set up apprentices for career success and establish an employee pipeline for participating agencies.

## REGISTERED VS. PRE-APPRENTICESHIP

### Pre-Apprenticeship

### Registered Apprenticeship

**Provide Competency-Based Employment Training**

**Critical for Youth with Disabilities to Transition to Independence**

A program or set of strategies designed to prepare individuals to enter and succeed in a Registered Apprenticeship Program (RAP).

A proven model of apprenticeship validated by the US Department of Labor (DOL) or State Apprenticeship Agency.

May last from a few weeks to a few months and may or may not include wages or stipend.

RAPs must demonstrate they have met national standards for registration.

Elements of a quality pre-apprenticeship program as defined by the Department of Labor (DOL):

- Approved curriculum
- Simulated experience
- Facilitated entry
- Increased access
- Supportive services
- Sustainable partnerships

Administering and maintaining RAPs is the sponsor's responsibility. Each sponsor receives a seal of approval and DOL funding opportunities.

There may be workforce development funds and other support from federal, state, and local partners.

**Goals Include:**

- **Increasing youth participation**
- **Placing individuals on a pathway to employability**

## Project Partners

The RYAD Project is a project of ExploreVR at the Institute for Community Inclusion, UMass Boston, in partnership with:

- Mathematica Policy Research
- Montana Rural Institute for Inclusive Communities
- Arkansas Rehabilitation Services
- Arkansas Career Development Center

ExploreVR offers VR agencies easy and convenient access to a range of VR research, related data, training and tools for planning, evaluation, and decision-making.

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